Bellyfruit

By Maria Bernhard, Susannah Blinkoff, Janet Borrus

CHRISTINA, female, age 16, Caucasian

ARLENE, female, mid-30's, Christina's mother

CHRISTINA: You know how you can only get pregnant like two days out of the month? That's when I took the pill! Before I had my baby, I did some modeling at the mall, but they don't call me no more. I wasn't thinking about having a baby when I was having sex. I was thinking about having *sex* when I was having sex... like most people, right?

INTRODUCTION

According to Victor Strausburg of the New Mexico School of Medicine, one million teens in the USA will become pregnant over the next twelve months. Ninety-five percent of those pregnancies will be unintended. About one third will end in abortion; one third will end in spontaneous miscarriage; and one third will continue their pregnancy to term and keep their baby. More than half of these teen mothers will be 17 years old or younger. Why? Some say it's because we don't educate about birth control in sex education classes, we don't discuss it at home, and we don't give teens good access to it. Some say it's because abstinence is not a value passed on to our kids at home or in school. Regardless of the reasons, the facts remain the same . . . Children are having children. Bellyfruit by Maria Bernhard, Susannah Blinkoff, Janet Borrus puts a face and a name with this crisis. You've already met Christina. This is her story.

CHRISTINA: I had sex with seven guys last Saturday. Not many girls can say that. See, I decided not to feel bad about who I am and just accept that I'm a slut. It's what I am. You don't always get to choose what you are. I tried to change. It doesn't work. Last weekend I went to a party with my best friend. I was gonna be this whole new person,

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right? I wasn't gonna just get wasted and go off with some guy. But as soon as her boyfriend showed up she ditched me. Then practically everybody started pairing up, and I just kind of stood there feeling...stupid. Then I saw this whole other group of guys sitting on the wall. And they were all looking at me. They started calling me "sexy girl" and "beautiful." It made me feel good. I took off this sweater I had on over this kind of crop top thing. I downed one of their beers and started making out with one of them. Then, somehow, I was sitting on one of the other guy's laps and... then everything got really wild. The guys took me to a park. I tried to run but I was in the middle of this mass of men. At first, I was scared but then there was nothing I could do. They were all undressing me and undressing themselves, grabbing at me and...I don't really remember. Anyway, that's it. I did them all. Not many girls can say they did what I did.

[SCENE BREAK]

CHRISTINA: I slept in the bathtub last night. I watched this really scary movie about two sisters and one is really evil and the other one is in a wheelchair. It freaked me out so bad, I had to sleep in the bathroom 'cause it's the only door in the house that has a lock. My mom's been gone four days this time... 'sposed to be just the weekend. She usually calls, unless she's really drunk. I hope she's OK. She's fine. Guess she got lucky. Whatever. I don't care, I just wish she'd left me some money. They turned the gas off on Friday so I'm, like,

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wearing six sweaters. But it's not a tragedy or anything. We have a microwave. She finally returns to find me in the bathroom . . .

[To CHRISTINA and her mother ARLENE in the bathroom of their apartment.]

ARLENE: Why'd you have to lock the bathroom door? I thought you overdosed or slit your wrists or something.

CHRISTINA: Not yet.

ARLENE: Don't start. God, I need coffee.

CHRISTINA: Good luck. The gas got turned off.

ARLENE: They said I had 'til the end of the month! Shit, I was gonna pay it, I just needed cash this weekend. *[Sighs.]* I'm a lousy mother, right?

CHRISTINA: *[Reciting her usual response.]* No, you're not.

ARLENE: C'mon, I'll take us out to breakfast.

CHRISTINA: I have school, Mom.

ARLENE: I haven't seen you all weekend, I want to tell you about Frank. I need advice.

CHRISTINA: Frank? What happened to Gary?

ARLENE: Gary is an [jerk]. Frank's the one.

CHRISTINA: Did you tell him about me?

ARLENE: Frank needs more time to fall in love with me but soon I'll tell him all about you. Then you'll have a father.

CHRISTINA: I don't want a father.

ARLENE: You want the bills paid?

CHRISTINA: I want someone to love me. . . I want a family, not a father.

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[Lights crossfade to CHRISTINA in her bathroom.]

CHRISTINA: It's been three months now and I know. I haven't been to the doctor yet, but I don't have to have a doctor tell me what I can feel. My butt's getting bigger and my boobs - Like, storing up fat for some future time, like I'm some kind of Eskimo or something. And I haven't told anyone yet. Sometimes I want to tell like a total stranger on the bus. Or sometimes I just wanna pull up my sweatshirt in front of my mom and her new boyfriend and yell: "Surprise!" No one has any idea. I still go to parties and stuff but I wear really baggy clothes so nobody notices. I don't know which guy it was. But it doesn't really matter. It's not like any of these guys are gonna help me out at all. But, you know, a lot of women are alone when they're having a baby, so I'll be just like them. I don't think I'd want any of those guys around anyway. I mean, they're not *fathers,* they're just guys. They were just having sex. Like I was.

[SCENE BREAK]

CHRISTINA: At the hospital, everyone kept asking me about the father. They gave me all these forms to fill out and all the real fathers it could be just blurred in my head: the guys on the field, that boy from Spanish class, my friend's brother, the guy at the 7-11...and I just started crying. This nurse came up to me and asked me what was wrong and I told her I didn't know and she said: What? What don't you know? And I said, "I don't know who the father is!" I felt so stupid. Like,

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yeah, I'm really popular now, right? So she says: You can get the different men to come in for a test ...and I'm, like, picturing the guys at my school. No way am I gonna go up to, like, thirty different guys and say, "Hi! I don't know if this is your kid, but if you could just come down to the hospital for a test..." And then I realized I don't even like any of them and that was too depressing. So I told the nurse that the father moved out of state and I don't know where he is. And she said: Oh, I see, and wrote "Unknown" in about a million places on the page. Sometimes I feel like I made a really big mistake...

[SCENE BREAK]

CHRISTINA: I have a huge scar. It's really gross. They had to cut me open 'cause the baby came five weeks too early. I felt like I was in a magic trick, you know, like I was the girl inside the box with everybody watching while the guy saws me in half. They cut my stomach open! Like I will ever wear a crop top again, right? But then the nurse.. .she puts this little wet person on my chest and I could see these little fingernails and toes, her little ear was right over my heart and then she opened up these blue *amazing* eyes and looked right at me. She's the most incredible and perfect thing I've ever seen! And she came out of me...which proves I'm not as [messeed] up as I thought, you know?

[Lights up on ARLENE in apartment. CHRISTINA enters, slightly drunk.]

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ARLENE: You're forty minutes late, Christina! We agreed that you'd be home by . . .

CHRISTINA: Hi, baby! Hi, sweetie, did you miss me?

ARLENE: Shhh! She finally just fell asleep. *[ARLENE gives the baby to CHRISTINA.]* What, you can't tell time?

CHRISTINA: The party rocked and no one wanted to leave! I couldn't get a ride

ARLENE: She cried and screamed all night. She drove me crazy.

CHRISTINA: She cried for me? Ohhh, you missed me, little sweetie, didn't you. Well, mommy won't leave you ever again, I promise.

ARLENE: Right. Not 'til there's another rockin' party.

CHRISTINA: I'm just trying to meet someone, okay? Sound familiar?

ARLENE: It's not that easy, trust me. I gave up everything when I had you! Everything!

CHRISTINA: SO I was forty minutes late, so what, mom! Don't shit lightning bolts.

ARLENE: You don't get it, do you? I am not your babysitter! I already DID this, I raised you all by myself for sixteen years!

CHRISTINA: Mom

ARLENE: No, Christina! You got pregnant, not me! This is your mess, not mine!

[SCENE BREAK]

CHRISTINA: I miss school. I never thought I would, but I do. I can't believe my mom let me do whatever I wanted. I'm gonna be strict with *my* kid. All I do with my baby is watch T.V: We never go out or nothin'. No

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guys go out with you if you have a kid. I go for every job I hear about, but they all say the same thing. "What if your kid gets sick? We can't depend on you." When she's 16 I'll be 30. That's not too old to go to college. Is it?

[SCENE BREAK]

[Lights up on CHRISTINA with her baby, knocking on an apartment door.]

CHRISTINA: Hi, um, I'm Christina and this is my daughter and, uh.. .we're kind a stuck. John lets us stay here sometimes. I can't stay with my mom 'cause her new boyfriend can't deal with the baby crying, he gets migraines and he's pissed off 'cause I borrowed some money without asking. I was gonna tell him. Anyway, I went to this shelter place in Hollywood but I could only stay two weeks. And then I slept in this van with a guy and his girlfriend and their baby but it was really crowded and then they got lice and...I mean, I'm not, like, homeless. I'm not gonna end up to be one of those people who gets their baby taken away by the county. I'm a normal person! I was popular, okay? But now it's like...we don't even have a place to sleep. Aren't people supposed to *like* babies?

[SCENE BREAK]

CHRISTINA: I look into my baby's eyes and I see how innocent she is. She doesn't expect the worst from everybody...and I'm gonna keep it that way. I used to think, like, everything is temporary, you know, don't nothin' last... but now that I have my kid it's just like my mama said: People come and go, but children are forever.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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